

LinguaLounge IPA Reference Sheet: German

Base language: English - / / = broad phonemic IPA, [] = common phonetic realization.
Regional pronunciation can vary.

Scope

Standard German. The rhotic is shown as /ʀ/ in examples, but real speakers may use [ʁ], [R], [r], or vocalized [ɐ].

VOWELS

Category	IPA symbols
Short vowels	/a ɛ ɪ ɔ ʊ ʏ œ ə/
Long vowels	/aː eː iː oː uː yː øː ɛː/
Diphthongs	/aɪ aʊ ɔʏ/

CONSONANTS

Category	IPA symbols
Plosives	/p b t d k g ʔ/
Fricatives	/f v s z ʃ ʒ x h ʁ ʒ/
Affricates	/pf ts tʃ dʒ/
Nasals	/m n ŋ/
Liquids / approximants	/l j/ plus rhotic /ʀ/

ALPHABET AND COMMON SPELLING VALUES

The table gives common learner-safe values. Some letters have additional values in loanwords, names, or regional speech.

Letter / spelling	Main IPA value	Example	Notes
A a	/a, a:/	Amt /amt/, Name /'na:mə/	Short or long depending on spelling and word.
B b	/b/	Bahn /ba:n/	Word-final obstruents devoice: ab /ap/.
C c	/k/ or /t͡s/	Computer /kɔm'pjʊ:tə/, Celsius /'t͡sɛlzjʊs/	Rare in native words; mostly loanwords.
D d	/d/	Dame /'da:mə/	Word-final obstruents devoice: Rad /ʁa:t/.
E e	/e:, ɛ, ə/	Esel /'e:zəl/, Ende /'ɛndə/	Final -e is often /ə/.
F f	/f/	Fisch /fɪʃ/	
G g	/g/	gut /gu:t/, Tag /ta:k/	Final g often devoices to /k/.
H h	/h/ or silent length marker	Haus /haʊs/, sehen /'ze:ən/	After a vowel, h often only marks length.
I i	/i:, ɪ/	Igel /'i:gəl/, Kind /kɪnt/	
J j	/j/	Jahr /ja:ɐ/	
K k	/k/	Kind /kɪnt/	
L l	/l/	Lampe /'lampə/	
M m	/m/	Mann /man/	
N n	/n/	Nacht /naxt/	Before k/g, n may be /ŋ/: Bank /baŋk/.
O o	/o:, ɔ/	Ofen /'o:fən/, oft /ɔft/	
P p	/p/	Pause /'paʊzə/	
Pf pf	/p͡f/	Pferd /p͡fe:ɐt/	One affricate, not two separate sounds.
Q q	/kv/	Quelle /'kvɛlə/	Almost always qu = /kv/.
R r	/ʀ/; vocalized /ɐ/	rot /ʀo:t/, Jahr /ja:ɐ/	Regional rhotic variation is normal.
S s	/z/ or /s/	Sonne /'zɔnə/, Bus /bʊs/	Word-initial before a vowel usually /z/.
Sch sch	/ʃ/	Schule /'ʃu:lə/	
T t	/t/	Tag /ta:k/	
U u	/u:, ʊ/	Uhr /u:ɐ/, Mutter /'mʊtɐ/	
V v	/f/ or /v/	Vater /'fa:tə/, Vase /'va:zə/	/v/ is common in loanwords.
W w	/v/	Wasser /'vase/	
X x	/ks/	Taxi /'taksi/	
Y y	/y:, ʏ/	Typ /ty:p/	Mostly loanwords.
Z z	/t͡s/	Zeit /t͡saɪt/	
Ä ä	/ɛ, ɛ:/	Männer /'mɛnɐ/	Often long /ɛ:/ or /e:/ depending on word and speaker.
Ö ö	/ø:, œ/	schön /ʃø:n/, Hölle /'hœlə/	
Ü ü	/y:, ʏ/	Tür /ty:ɐ/, Hütte /'hytə/	
ß	/s/	Straße /'ʃtʁa:sə/	Never word-initial; follows a long vowel or diphthong.

IMPORTANT SPELLING AND PRONUNCIATION NOTES

Final devoicing	Voiced obstruents become voiceless at the end of a word or syllable: Tag /ta:k/, Rad /ʁa:t/.
ich-Laut / ach-Laut	ch is /ç/ after front vowels and many consonants: ich /ɪç/. It is /x/ after back vowels: Bach /bax/.
Long vowels	Long vowels often appear before a single consonant, with h as a length marker, or as ie = /i:/.
Stress	Stress usually falls on the first syllable of the main root, but compounds, prefixes, and loanwords vary.